

Introduction Of Suicide Theory

Durkheim on the basis of his monographic studies claims suicide as primarily a social phenomena in terms of the breakdown of the vital bond of life. Durkheim in his classical study of 'Le Suicide' which was published in 1897, demonstrates that neither psycho-pathic factor nor heredity nor climate nor poverty, nor unhappy love nor other personal factors motivate along form sufficient explanation of suicide

Durkheim has established the view that there are no societies in which suicide does not occur.

According to Durkheim, suicide is not an individual act nor a personal action. It is caused by some power which is over and above the individual or super individual. Many doctors and psychologists develop the theory that majority of people who take their own life are in a pathological state, but Durkheim emphasises that the force, which determines the suicide, is not psychological but social.

He concludes that suicide is the result of social disorganisation or lack of social integration or social solidarity.

Durkheim's Definition of Suicide

Durkheim defines suicide as a “general state of extreme depression and exaggerated sadness, causing the patient no longer to realize sanely the bonds which connect him with the people and things about him –pleasures no longer attract”

TYPES OF SUICIDE

Durkheim identifies four different types of suicide which are

Egoistic suicide
Altruistic suicide
Anomic suicide
Fatalistic suicide

Egoistic suicide

According to Durkheim, when a man becomes socially isolated or feels that he has no place in the society he destroys himself. This is the suicide of self-centred person who lacks altruistic feelings and is usually cut off from main stream of the society.

These individuals are unable to find their own place in society and have problems adjusting to groups. They received little and no social care. Suicide is seen as a solution for them to free themselves from loneliness or excessive individuation.

Example

When Suicide Is done by an elderly person living alone is considered as egoistic suicide

Altruistic suicide

This type of suicide occurs when individuals and the group are too close and intimate. This kind of suicide results from the over integration of the individual into social proof

Altruistic suicide occurs when social group involvement is too high. Individuals are so well integrated into the group that they are willing to sacrifice their own life in order to fulfil some obligation for the group

Individuals kill themselves for the collective benefit of the group or for the cause that the group believes in

For Example

1)An example is someone who commits suicide for the sake of a religious or political cause

2)Sati customs, Dannies warriors etc

Anomic suicide

Anomic suicide is caused by the lack of social regulation and it occurs during high levels of stress and frustration.

Anomic suicide stems from sudden and unexpected changes in situations

In simple words, Anomic suicide takes place in a situation which has cropped up suddenly.

For example

When individuals suffer extreme financial loss, the disappointment and stress that individuals face may drive them towards committing suicide as a means of escape.

Fatalistic suicide

This type of suicide is due to overregulation in society. Fatalistic suicide occurs when individuals are kept under tight regulation. These individuals are placed under extreme rules or high expectations are set upon them, which removes a person's sense of self or individuality.

For Example

Slavery and persecution are examples of fatalistic suicide where individuals may feel that they are destined by fate to be in such conditions and choose suicide as the only means of escaping such conditions